

ENDANGERED: A one-horned rhino in Kaziranga



# HORNS OF A DILEMMA

The killing of four rhinos in five weeks this year puts a question mark on the management of the Kaziranga National Park as the successful conservation story faces a serious setback

■ By Kaushik Deka in Kaziranga

As the image of a rhinoceros, wobbling in pain—blood oozing from where its horn was sawed off—was splashed across newspapers and television monitors, it not only rattled animal lovers across the country, but raised a few uncomfortable questions about the management of the Kaziranga National Park (KNP). It's ironical because the park celebrated its centennial only three years back amid rich praises for the authorities for their success in preserving the highly endangered one-horned rhino.

The applause came not without a reason. According to the Government, 650 one-horned rhinos have been killed in Kaziranga in the past 40 years. Of that, 550 were killed by poachers between 1980 and 1997 alone—the highest being 48 in 1992. But there was a marked reduction in the killings between 1998 and 2006 when just 47 rhinos were killed. In fact, the number increased from 1,164 in 1993 to 1,855 in 2006. "The decline in killings was due to intensive security measures, better

## SUDDEN DEATH

Poaching figure touched double digit in 2007, for the first time in a decade



intelligence network, coupled with support from villagers living on the periphery of the park," says Dharanidhar Boro, forest ranger at KNP.

But things came back to square one last year, when 16 rhinos were killed—unofficial reports put the figure at 20—inside the park, compared to just five in 2006. Interestingly, the top management of the park was changed last year and this was the first time in a decade when the number of rhinos killed in a year touched a double-digit

figure. The UNESCO heritage site is now facing one of its biggest crisis as this year four pachyderms have been killed in a span of just five weeks.

While environmentalists attribute the sudden spurt in killings to the Government's negligence and lax security system, one NGO has even claimed that there is a nexus between officials and poachers. A stinker was raised after cartridges of .315 rifles were found at the site where a female rhino and its calf was killed on January